LOOPSIGNAL · LOOPSCAN

Sample findings pack

Northfield Manufacturing — open purchase-order follow-up

Fictional plant. Fictional data. Not a client engagement.

> This is a complete sample LoopScan, start to finish. It was built on the same fictional Northfield dataset used in the public demos. Nothing here is from a real plant.

LoopScan is a two-day on-site review of how a process actually runs. This pack is what comes back: a current-state map, the friction, the information gaps, the system connections, the repetitive work, what to automate and what not to, and one prioritized next step with business impact.

Engagement

Two days on site · findings in 10 business days
$7,500 · unconditional 7-day guarantee

Plant time

Sponsor ~3 hrs · Buyer or planner ~5 hrs
One operator ~2 hrs · IT ~1 hr

Process in scope

How buyers learn that an open order is late, confirm a date with the supplier, and get that date to planning before the line is short.

What was walked

Workflows, Epicor, Excel, Outlook, a shared supplier-contact sheet, the morning production meeting, and the coverage file planning keeps separately.

How to read this

Every number below is from the fictional Northfield open-order file as of 15 Aug 2026, plus time observed in the sample process. Treat it as an example of the shape of a LoopScan, not as a claim about your plant.

1 · CURRENT-STATE WORKFLOW MAP

How late orders get followed up today

01 Buyer J. Chen exports the open-PO report from Epicor to Excel at 6:40 a.m.

02 Filters for past-due and due-within-three-days. Sorts by supplier so emails can be batched.

03 Looks up who to call in a shared spreadsheet. Three suppliers are not in it; those names live in Chen's Outlook.

04 Sends follow-up mail from Outlook. Replies land in the inbox, not in Epicor.

05 Pastes promised dates into the morning spreadsheet. Does not write them back to the PO.

06 Prints the exception list. Walks it to planning before the 8:30 production meeting.

07 Planning copies shortages into a separate coverage workbook. Production hears the rest in the meeting.

08 If a line goes short during the day, the supervisor calls Chen. Chen searches yesterday's mail.

Eight steps. Four systems. One person who can run it if Chen is out.

Owners in the sample

ROLE	PERSON	WHAT THEY ACTUALLY DO IN THIS PROCESS
Buyer	J. Chen	Export, chase, translate replies, carry the list to planning
Buyers	M. Alvarez, K. Brooks, R. Patel	Own other supplier families; do not share a common chase list
Planning	Coverage workbook owner	Rebuilds a second view of the same shortages
Production	Assembly supervisors	Learn shortages at 8:30, or when the line stops

2 · FRICTION POINTS

Where the work stalls

FRICTION	WHAT WE SAW
The list is rebuilt every morning	Same Epicor export, same filters, same sort. Chen’s timed sample: 22 minutes before the first supplier email goes out.
Confirmation lives in mail	A promised date in Outlook is not a promised date in Epicor. Planning cannot see it without Chen.
Seven orders have no supplier-confirmed date	POs 450801, 450818, 450901, 450918, 450930, 450944, 451002. Summit Packaging accounts for four of the seven.
Past-due is discovered after the date has passed	450218 Machined Shaft (Apex) is 10 days past due, 240 open, 6 days of coverage on the floor. 450106 Steel Tubing (Ridgeway) is 14 days past due with no on-hand coverage in the file.
The walk to planning	The exception list is a printout. If Chen is in a supplier call at 8:25, the meeting starts without it.
One person	Supplier contacts for Apex and Harbor are not in the shared sheet. If Chen is out, those chases wait.

3 · INFORMATION GAPS

What the process cannot see

- Epicor open-PO report does not carry a promised date as a first-class field in the export Chen uses. Seven rows are blank.
- Inventory coverage is on some rows (MS-240, PH-18, PF-120) and missing on others. Planning’s workbook has the rest, in a different file.
- No shared view of “who was already emailed today,” so Alvarez and Chen have both written Harbor on the same morning.
- Production does not see open-order risk until the meeting, or until Assembly Line 1 waits on stainless fasteners.

4 · SYSTEM CONNECTIONS

What talks to what — and what does not

FROM	TO	HOW IT MOVES
Epicor	Chen’s Excel	Manual export, every morning
Shared contact sheet	Outlook	Copy / paste. Three suppliers are only in Chen’s inbox.
Supplier replies	Excel exception list	Paste. Not written back to the PO.
Excel exception list	Planning coverage file	Printout, then re-key
Planning coverage file	Production meeting	Spoken. No board, no persistent list.

Nothing in this chain is broken. It is disconnected. Each hop is a person.

5 · REPETITIVE WORK

What gets done again tomorrow

- Export, filter, sort: ~22 minutes, every morning Chen is in.
- Supplier mail for the same past-due Apex and Keystone rows until a date is pasted into Excel — then the next morning the export does not have that date, so the row looks late again.
- Planning re-keys the same shortages into the coverage workbook.
- The printed list is thrown away after the meeting. The next day starts from Epicor again.

On a 5-day week this is a little under two hours of buyer time before anyone has confirmed a date, plus the planning re-key. The sample does not count the supervisor calls when a line actually goes short.

Technology follows the process

Do this without software first

- Put a promised-date column on the PO and make it part of the export Chen already runs.
- Move Apex, Harbor, and Summit contacts into the shared sheet. One list.
- Write confirmed dates back to the PO the same day they arrive, so tomorrow's export does not resurrect yesterday's chase.
- Stop printing. Planning gets the same list Chen already has, before 8:30.

Worth automating after that

- A daily exception list that already applies the past-due / due-soon / no-promise rules, so the 22-minute rebuild goes away.
- A follow-up draft for the seven no-promise rows, sitting behind a human send.
- A single shortage view planning and production can both see. Not a second workbook.

Do not automate yet

- Auto-sending supplier mail. Chen still decides who gets a second chase.
- An ERP replacement. Epicor is not the constraint. The hops around it are.
- A dashboard for its own sake. The meeting already exists. It needs a list that is true at 8:25.

One change, with business impact

Next step: Stop rebuilding the chase list. Make promised date a field on the PO, include it in the morning export, and write every supplier confirmation back the day it arrives. Run one shared exception list — past due, due within three days, no promise — and give planning that list before the 8:30 meeting.

That is a process change plus a small change to a report that already exists. It does not require a new system.

Why this one first

- It removes the 22-minute daily rebuild and the false re-chase of rows that were already confirmed in mail.
- It puts the seven no-promise orders on a list someone can finish, instead of discovering them mixed into a 20-row export.
- It gives planning the same truth the buyer has, before production is in the room.
- It is reversible in a week if it is wrong. The guarantee exists for the same reason.

What this is not

This is not an ERP project, a hiring plan, or a recommendation to automate the chase before the list is true. If Northfield were a real plant, the next conversation would be whether to install that exception list as a LoopBuild, or whether the process change is enough.
